competing with China. Muni argues that India's "neighbourhood first" policy is increasingly shaped by the need to provide its neighbours an alternative to China, and that when India lacks the resources to do it alone, it invites the United States and Japan to assist in countering Chinese economic influence. Hence, even if New Delhi promotes increased economic cooperation with Beijing, it also views China's trade and investments in the region as a concern and competes with China for influence.

Diplomacy

India conducts an active diplomacy with China, both in a bilateral setting as well as within regional and multilateral organisations. The most high profile of these in recent years were the "informal summits" between Modi and Xi held in Wuhan and Chennai in 2018 and 2019, respectively. In fact, the number of high-level visits and exchanges between India and China has increased significantly over the last few years and includes events like the Russia-India–China trilateral, the BRICS summit, and a number of meetings within the framework of Association for Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN)-plus.

In 2017, India also joined the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO). Even though New Delhi and Beijing have come together at several multilateral forums such as BRICS, the East Asia Summit, and the ASEAN Regional Forum (ARF), the SCO is a profoundly China-led organisation. However, as pointed out by Stobdan, although the SCO is a venue for India to collaborate with China on a number of issues. India will also stand up for its interests and values in the SCO, and India's motives for joining the SCO go beyond China and include the possibility of